



Plant products

Plants provide many of the materials we use every day. From tree trunks we harvest timber to build houses, wood to turn into paper, and resins to make varnish. Dyes can be made from berries and leaves, and textiles from plant fibers. Some plants have many uses. In Malaysia, for example, the coconut palm is called the “tree of a thousand uses” because almost every part of this tree is useful.

Fruit ➤ The large, smooth fruits of the coconut palm contain a seed known as the coconut. It has a hard, hairy shell and edible white flesh.

Coconut water, the liquid found inside the immature seed, is a delicious drink that is rich in nutrients.



Utensils, such as this cup, can be carved from coconut shells.



Ropes can be made from coir, the fibers of the coconut husk.



Oil is extracted from the white flesh for use in cooking.

Logs of coconut timber are often used in construction because they do not decay easily.



Musical instruments, such as this Hawaiian pahu drum, are made from coconut timber.



Trunk ➤ Coconut palms can grow up to 98 ½ ft (30 m) tall. Their slender, flexible trunks, which have a ringed pattern, allow them to bend rather than break in strong winds.